

MICHELLE SINGLETARY: SCAMMED

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IMAGES OF 2024

A visual journey through an eventful year **SPECIAL SECTION**



FOOD

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The Washington Post

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Suspect in slaying of CEO took stark turn

Those who knew him in school recall a well-liked, promising student leader

BY DAN DIAMOND,
OLIVIA GEORGE
AND ANNIE GOWEN

BALTIMORE — Luigi Mangione was a young prince of this city, his family's name emblazoned on the walls of buildings and civic institutions. Teachers at his elite prep school described him as a student leader, on his way to an Ivy League education. Classmates called the valedictorian, athlete and budding engineer an inspiration, someone focused on society's future. More accolades followed at college in Philadelphia.

Then came worsening back pain, time abroad and a period of discontent. Friends said they lost track of the 26-year-old this year, struggling to confirm his participation in a wedding; his mother filed a missing-person report.

As Mangione's once-chaunted life seemed to be crumbling, Brian Thompson's fortunes appeared to be climbing. The 50-year-old executive, from a small town in Iowa, was entering his fourth year as CEO of the nation's largest health insurer, UnitedHealthcare, where he was well-liked by employees and respected

The Critique: No heroes, but plenty to grieve, in CEO's killing. **A2**

Extradition: Suspect fights efforts to send him to New York. **A18**



If approved, large landowners would have to get clearance to build in the insect's habitat.

U.S. moves to list monarch butterfly as threatened

BY DINO GRANDONI

U.S. officials moved Tuesday to protect the monarch, an iconic orange-and-black butterfly famous for its marathon migration across North America, under the Endangered Species Act.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service's proposal to designate the tiny migrating butterfly as threatened with extinction could have enormous consequences for landowners across its huge range, which extends across much of the Lower 48 as the monarch makes its epic annual flight from the mountains of Mexico through the United States and into Canada.

If the proposed rule is finalized, the monarch would become one of the most widespread species ever protected under the 1973 law. But federal scientists say the move is necessary because several factors — including climate change, logging in the butterfly's overwintering habitat in Mexico, destruction of grasslands in the

SEE **MONARCH** ON **A9**



People examine records Tuesday at Syria's infamous Sednaya prison near Damascus as they search for information on loved ones.

Sifting through a 'slaughterhouse' and its secrets

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS
AND SUZAN HAIDAMOUS

SEDNAYA PRISON, SYRIA — The grounds of Syria's most notorious prison are strewn with scraps of paper, offering clues to the horrors meted out within its walls.

One order from 2020, signed by the head of the facility, refers in clinical language to an "administrative matter," ordering a Syrian officer to "blindfold the detainees for the implementation of the aforementioned decision . . . in complete secrecy." An accompanying letter with the most vital details — including the identity of the detainees — was nowhere to be found.

Desperate to learn fates of relatives, Syrians are gripped by gnawing fear

Since the fall on Sunday morning of Bashar al-Assad — who presided for 24 years over the totalitarian police state he inherited from his father — desperate families have come to this dusty hill 20 miles north of Damascus, home to the Sednaya military prison, where rights groups say torture was inflicted on an industrial scale, and where thousands upon thousands of people simply

disappeared. Executions here were so commonplace it became known to Syrians as the "slaughterhouse."

As families roamed Sednaya's sprawling geography Tuesday, poring over papers recovered from its offices and passing around nooses discovered in some of its cells, they were gripped by a gnawing fear that they would not learn the fate of their missing loved ones — that so much of what happened here may never be known.

"I'm coming every day, and every day more of my hopes are lost," Hannan Odeh, 43, said of the search for her brother, who has been missing for the past decade.

At points, Sednaya held as many as 20,000 prisoners, Amnesty International has found. Few made it out alive; land mines in the surrounding countryside were waiting for those who tried to escape.

Of the 145,000 Syrians detained through September 2019 during the course of the country's civil war, nearly 90 percent were taken by the government, according to the Syrian Network for Human Rights. Of those, more than 80,000 vanished without a trace, with many believed to have been held in Assad's extensive network of prisons.

Sednaya towered over them all.

SEE **SYRIA** ON **A8**

NIKKI GIOVANNI 1943-2024

Always a relevant force, dynamic poet explored Black life in verse

BY HARRISON SMITH

Nikki Giovanni, a poet of rage and revolution as well as love and longing, who emerged as a fiery voice of Black liberation in the 1960s before honing a more tender, meditative style in best-selling books for children and adults, died Dec. 9 at a hospital in Blacksburg, Virginia. She was 81.

The cause was cancer, according to a family statement shared by her friend Kwame Alexander, a poet and author. Ms. Giovanni had battled cancer twice already, according to the statement, and was still giving readings and performances as recently as last month, when she collaborated with saxophonist Javon Jackson for an event at the Louis Armstrong House in Queens.

Across more than five decades and three dozen books, Ms. Giovanni wrote poetry and prose that bridged the public and private spheres, celebrating Black identity, attacking white supremacy and extolling ordinary pleasures such as artichoke soup and a mother's warm embrace. Her work often paid homage to earlier Black artists and activists, and made her an elder stateswoman among African American poets.

"Me, I only wanted to be a voice," she wrote in "I Am in

SEE **GIOVANNI** ON **A5**



2004 PHOTO BY MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

Nikki Giovanni was a preeminent American poet who emerged as a strong voice of Black liberation in the 1960s. Her expressive style evolved over the years at Virginia Tech, where she was a professor.

On Discord, a sadistic group sees opportunity

Man's suicide shows how platform has been used to find vulnerable people

BY SHAWN BOBURG
AND CHRIS DEGHANPOOR

Samuel Hervey, a 25-year-old in the throes of a severe mental health crisis, positioned his phone so its camera would capture the gruesome spectacle that was about to unfold.

The Minnesota native stepped into the frame of the video live stream, his long hair spilling from the hood of a white sweatshirt. He sat down cross-legged and emptied a plastic bottle filled with gasoline onto his head and his clothing. Then he lit a flame.

As fire engulfed him, more than two dozen people watched in a private video chatroom on the popular messaging app Discord. They laughed, cheered and congratulated themselves, according to a recording reviewed by The Washington Post.

Among those watching the November 2021 live stream was a 15-year-old girl in an Eastern European city who had spent much of the previous week in close contact with Hervey, urging him in private messages and voice calls to take his life on camera, The Post found. It was an effort, she later said in an interview, to impress others in a global online community that rewards cruelty.

"I was getting my big break," she recalled thinking during Hervey's suicide. "It was a competition of who could do the worst thing. So I obviously felt very cool."

The circumstances leading to Hervey's self-immolation remained mostly a mystery to his family and friends and to law enforcement. The Post traced the suicide to the online community known as "764" and found that it was enabled by a messaging app the group has used to find victims halfway across the globe and lure them into closed, largely unmoderated spaces.

Hervey's path into a virtual den of predation — and the role of a



A top honor for Thomas Boswell

The longtime writer and columnist for The Post won the Baseball Writers' Association of America's Career Excellence Award and will be honored at the Baseball Hall of Fame in July. **D1**